

A Method for Learning Open Position Chords

Playing open position triads is one of the most deceptively simple skills beginning guitarists attempt to acquire. These “basic” chords are often some of the first things aspiring guitarists are taught by a teacher or a friend and often end up being the source of much frustration. When we stop and examine what we’re asking our left hands to do in order to play any series of chords, we see that, in reality, this is much more complicated than we often acknowledge.

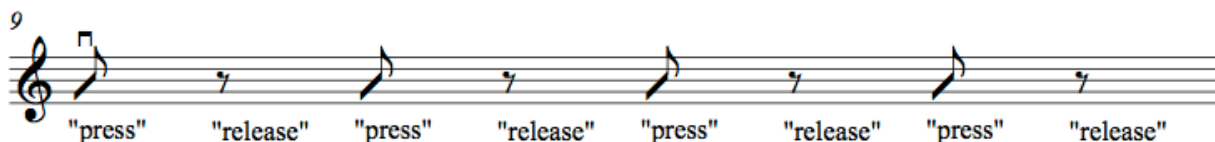
The first impediment to playing chords effectively is hand position and posture. If you’ve ever tried to play a chord and found it hard to stretch to reach some of the notes, or that you fingers were inadvertently muting adjacent strings, you should examine your positioning. The most efficient way to play the guitar is with the left wrist relatively neutral (just slightly arched) and with the thumb in the middle of the neck, or lower, such that the “big” or “top” joints of the fingers are even with the bottom edge of the fingerboard. This may require that you raise the guitar up a bit with the use of a foot stool or strap. The neutral wrist will allow you to stretch your fingers apart more easily and the correct thumb position will allow you to float your fingers in gentle arches over the fingerboard and bring the finger tips straight down into the strings.

The big issue, however, is independence of the fingers. If you already know how to play them, take a look at what your fingers need to do to transition from a G chord to a D chord; it’s a pretty complicated process, with each of your first three fingers moving different distances and in different directions to one another. And they said this would be easy!

To give yourself an advantage when learning chords, I suggest you do a lot of preparatory exercises to train to move the fingers independently and with good mechanics. Any scales are great, though I like doing 4-note chromatic patterns on each string, using various permutations of 4 fingers per string: 1234, 4321, 2341, 3214, etc... There are 24 possibilities and these exercises allow you to work out every finger equally.

Another detail that is often overlooked is the quick release of tension once any given task is completed. Most of us don’t do this naturally; we hold on to the tension of the previous task and move onto the next. This creates enormous problems that many of us play for years without realizing; if we try to move from G to D, expecting our hands to do that whole twister game, and we are still holding onto the tension required to hold down the G chord, we are just fighting ourselves!

To develop the skill of quick release of tension, I suggest practicing all the chord exercises below (and any other exercises you’re working on) in the following manner at first:



Really focus on letting the tension immediately “evaporate” on the upbeat of every beat. Don’t lift the fingers actively, just identify what muscles are firing to push the chords into the finger board, let them release, and allow the strings to push the fingers back to neutral.

Now let's get into synchronizing the fingers and learning these chords. The chord progressions below were designed to help you learn some essential open-position chords in a quick and efficient manner. You'll notice that each pair of chords has at least one common finger, that is, a finger that doesn't move during the change of chord. If you play each practice progression in order, you'll see that you'll only have to worry about teaching one finger at a time a new move, which should make it easier to learn to make the transition between chords. Play each measure slowly and in time until it is like second nature, then move on to the next.

Left Hand fingering

Em G⁶ Em Em⁷ Em G Em Am⁷

Em Am Am C Em Cmaj⁷ Em C

It's a great exercise to start this sequence with a different finger each time; you might discover more glitches that way. Apply sequence to the transitions between D and all of the other chords in the key of G and between C and C. Even if you already know these chords, check this out, because this same concept will come in handy when learning other more complex chord voicings.

To make these exercises more interesting, try them with the following rhythms. Pay attention to down and up strums; use down strums on the downbeats, up strums on the upbeats.



Here are some additional open position chords to memorize:

